

carry out peer-to-peer transactions over the Internet, without requiring middlemen like payment gateways to authorise transactions.

"The block records some or all of the current transactions, and once it is completed, the block is time-stamped and hashed into the permanent database or blockchain.

"The blocks are linked to each other in a linear, chronological order where each new block contains the hashed details of the previous block. This creates a chain of transactional information, so that every block that is added protects information in the previous one," explains Kumar Abhishek, founder and CEO of ToneTag, a sound based proximity communication provider that enables contactless proximity communication, mobile payments, location based services, customer engagement services and more. The company recently adopted blockchain technology to make its transactions more secure.

Do Bitcoin, blockchain and distributed ledger technology (DLT) mean the same? People tend to use these terms interchangeably, much like they use Xerox to mean photocopier, but these are not the same.

A distributed ledger refers to a consensus of replicated, shared and synchronised data that is distributed across multiple locations, often spanning several institutions and individuals across the globe.

Bitcoin is one of the most well-known and earliest proven applications of DLT. It is a decentralised digital currency that enables you to make instant payments to anyone, anywhere in the world, without requiring any middlemen.

It is decentralised, that is, transaction management and money issuance are carried out collectively by the network. This is where the blockchain comes in.

Devised as a method to keep track of all confirmed Bitcoin transactions, the blockchain is one type of distributed ledger in which data is distributed as blocks that form a linear chain with each one connected to the previous.

As explained in Bitcoin wiki, "Bitcoin uses public-key cryptography, peer-to-peer networking and proof-of-work to process and verify payments. Bitcoins are sent (or signed over) from one address to another with each user potentially having many, many addresses. Each payment transaction is broadcast to the network and included in the

"Blockchain technology continues to redefine not only how the exchange sector operates, but the global financial economy as a whole."

—Bob Greifeld,
chief executive officer, NASDAQ

blockchain so that the included bitcoins cannot be spent twice. After an hour or two, each transaction is locked in time by the massive amount of processing power that continues to extend the blockchain. Using these techniques, Bitcoin provides a fast and extremely reliable payment network that anyone can use."

There are applications other than Bitcoin that use blockchain technology. And that blockchain is not the only form of DLT; there are others like Ethereum, Ripple, Hyperledger and MultiChain. But, by virtue of being the earliest and most famous example, Bitcoin, blockchain and DLT are used synonymously by many, and that is not always right.

In fact, blockchain technology can be used to develop apps more advanced than just supporting digital currency. This evolution is often known as Blockchain 2.0.

ToneTag's blockchain approach.

"Blockchain was implemented as a way to keep record of all Bitcoin

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